

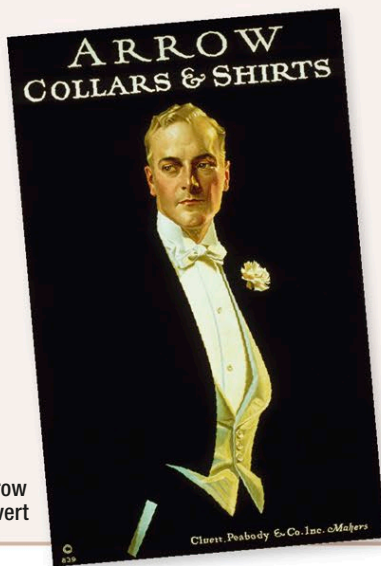
1920–1929

SETTING STANDARDS

Although there were no major additions to the vocabulary of men's formal wear in the 1920s, the move towards increasing informality continued in that decade. The constant changing of rules could cause anxiety and embarrassment. In the casinos of French resorts or at the dinner tables of ocean liners, a dinner suit or tuxedo was now considered appropriate when previously only full dress would have done. The tail or dress coat remained a must for an evening spent at the opera, a ball, or a formal dinner party where it provided the perfect foil for colourful, sparkling evening dresses. Frock coats could still be seen on city streets but mainly worn by older men. Magazines and etiquette books were prescriptive about what was considered good form, but those wealthy, famous, or good-looking enough such as Hollywood stars were granted a certain sartorial licence.

ARROW COLLAR MAN

This advertisement for collars and shirts bearing the American Arrow label sets almost unobtainable sartorial and physical standards. The stiff, white shirt front, wing collar, and white bow tie draw the eye to the typically chiselled feature of J.C. Leyendecker's creation. White carnations were the recommended buttonhole for full dress, although gardenias were also accepted. The illustration highlights the close fit of full dress, emphasizing the chest and confining the waist.



1927



Lanvin Although essentially the same as its pre-war predecessor, this Lanvin tailcoat is cut shorter to accommodate high-waisted trousers held up by braces. The French couturier's touch can be seen in the unusual closure of the waistcoat.

1920

Peaked, never notched, lapel

Black overcoat

Tails reach to knee

Trousers with pleated front

Narrow fit exaggerated in fashion illustration

At the opera Full dress consisted of tail coat, white waistcoat, stiff bosom shirt with wing collar, and white bow tie. Black top or opera hat and black patent leather boots or pumps completed the ensemble. Overcoats were a must, even in summer.

Top hat

